

Session 15: The Covenant of Circumcision

Key Takeaways

- Hagar plays out an an inverted prelude to the exodus. As an Egyptian slave fleeing oppression at the hands of Avram and Sarai, she meets God's mercy and blessing in the wilderness.
- Both Hagar and Avram face a de-creation and re-creation moment in this narrative—Hagar in wilderness and blessing, and Avram in circumcision and a new name.
- The covenant of circumcision reflects the language of God's covenant with Noah in Genesis 9. It is a sign both of God's judgment and his grace.

Yahweh Hears the Cry

The story of Yahweh hearing the cry of the oppressed and intervening to deliver and judge violent evil is an important template at work in Genesis 16. The hyperlinks to Genesis 4 and 6 portray Hagar among the righteous sufferers whose outcry reaches up to God.

At the spring (עין), Yahweh hears of the oppression (עני) of Hagar, and sends his messenger to deliver the righteous ([Gen. 16:7, 11](#)).

Genesis 4:10 Instructor's Translation

... What have you done? The voice of the shed-blood of your brother is crying out (צעק) to me from the ground.

Genesis 6:13 Instructor's Translation

An end of all flesh has come (קץ ... בא) up before me ...

Genesis 18:20-21 Instructor's Translation

The outcry (זעקה) against Sodom and Gomorrah is great ... the outcry (צעקה) has come up (באה) before me.

And in [Genesis 19:1](#), Yahweh sends his messengers to deliver the righteous.

This theme of the outcry of the oppressed rising up to God is at work in this story as well. Avraham and Sarai are portrayed as “doing violence” and “oppression” to their Egyptian slave. In each case of this design pattern, Yahweh enacts some kind of judgment against human evil.

Yahweh Hears the Cry

This story is remarkable because it follows the first mention of the future Egyptian enslavement of Israel in Genesis. The wordplay linkages are significant.

Genesis 15:13-14 Instructor's Translation

¹³ Know for certain that your seed will be **immigrants** (Heb. *ger* / גֵּר) in a land that is not theirs, and they will be enslaved to them, and they will **oppress** (Heb. *'anah* / עָנָה) them four hundred years. ¹⁴ But also that I myself will judge the nation whom to which they are slaves, and afterward they will come out with many possessions.

Genesis 16:1, 6 Instructor's Translation

¹ Now, Sarai ... had a slave-girl ... named **Hagar** (Heb. *ha-gar* / הַגֵּר = "The Immigrant")

⁶ And Sarai **oppressed** (Heb. *'anah* / עָנָה) her, and she fled.

Exodus 1:11 Instructor's Translation

And [the Egyptians] set over [the Israelites] captains of slave-labor, in order to **oppress** (עָנָה) them.

Long before the Egyptians deceived the Israelites and oppressed them, Avraham deceived Pharaoh and Sarai oppressed an Egyptian. The fact that this story precedes the exodus story means that the Egyptian slavery of Avraham's descendants becomes a tragically ironic reversal: Egypt does to Israel what Israel first did to Egypt.

There is some connection here to the laws about the treatment of immigrants in the covenant code, and the relationship to the Cain story (see [Exod. 22:21-23](#)).

Exodus 22:21-23 Instructor's Translation

²¹ You shall not wrong an immigrant (גֵּר) or oppress him, for you were immigrants in the land of Egypt. ²² You shall not oppress (עָנָה) any widow or orphan. ²³ If you intensely oppress (עָנָה תַעֲנֶה) him, and if he does cry out (צָעַק) to me, I will surely hear his outcry (צָעָקָה); ²⁴ and my anger will be hot (חַרָּה אֲפִי), and I will kill you (הָרַג) with the sword, and your wives shall become widows and your children fatherless.

Here are more links to the divided brothers pattern.

- [Genesis 16:12](#) "He will be a donkey of a man (פֶּרֶא אָדָם)" which recalls the "divided" (פֶּרֶד) motif of Noah's sons from [Genesis 10:5, 32](#).
- [Genesis 16:12b](#) "He will dwell against the face of all his brothers" is recalled in [Genesis 25:18](#), when Yishmael (Ishmael) settles in the east.

There is an important foundation being laid here for the "righteous non-elect" of the covenant family who dwells in the east. Just as many of the non-elect peoples in [Genesis 10](#) will later turn up as righteous gentiles or wicked gentiles, the same is true here with Yishmael. He and Hagar are the recipients of divine blessing ([Gen. 16:10](#) inverts [Gen. 3:16](#) and restates [Gen. 15:5](#), but now applied to Yishmael!). And while future conflict between Yishmael's descendants and Avraham's other future sons is anticipated, the oracle isn't entirely negative. Yishmael is included in the blessing of Avraham nonetheless.

Genesis 15-16 Replays Genesis 2-11 and 12-14

Genesis 2 • God's blessing of fruitful seed • Garden abundance • Sacred space of God's presence by the tree of life on Mt. Eden • Deep sleep and the provision of the delivering-help (עֲזָרָה)	Genesis 3 • Foolish failure at the tree of testing that is "good of sight" • She saw ... and took and gave • Deception and lack of trust in God's word • Exile from Eden	Genesis 4-6 • Brothers with abundance • Jealousy and conflict • Brothers "separate" through violence • Non-chosen brother settles in the east, where violence is simmering, leading to a flood of judgment	Violence, Flood, Remnant, Covenant (Gen. 6-9a)
Genesis 9:18-20 • Human blessing and abundance in a garden	Genesis 9:21-29 • Human folly in the garden • Sexual abuse in the tent • Family division and curse	Genesis 10:1-32 • Family, brothers divide and separate • Building of Babylon in east • Rebellion is simmering	Rebellion, Scattering, Remnant, Promise (Gen. 11)
Genesis 12:1-9 • God's blessing of abundance and protection • Promise of fruitful seed • God's presence at tree and mountains	Genesis 12:10-20 • Foolish failure with Sarai in Egypt who is "beautiful of sight" • Deception and lack of trust in God's word • Exile from false-Eden (i.e., Egypt) results in getting a slave	Genesis 13 • Brother with abundance • Jealousy and conflict • Brothers separate through non-violence! • Non-chosen brother settles in the east, where violence is simmering, leading up to a flood of judgment	Violence, Flood, Remnant, Covenant (Gen. 14)
Genesis 15:1-21 • God's blessing and promise of seed and land • Deep sleep and the provision of the seed (זֶרַע)	Genesis 16:1-6 • Foolish failure with Hagar the Egyptian slave • Sarai takes and gives to her husband • And she saw ... • "Do what's good in your eyes"	Genesis 16:7-16 • Yahweh meets non-chosen rival wife in the wilderness • Promise of a son whose hand will be against all his brothers	Violence, Flood, Remnant, Covenant (Gen. 17)
<i>Genesis 15-16 As a Replay.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).			

The story has portrayed both Avram and Sarai as humans who repeat their folly. Now, as the sequence of Genesis 15-16 replays the key elements of Genesis 12-13, both Avram and Sarai replay the folly of humanity

from Genesis 1-11. And so, for the second time, we expect there to be some kind of divine judgment that confronts the sin of foolish, violent humans and stems the tide of their destructive choices. This is precisely the theme of Genesis 17.

Covenant #2 With Avraham: Sign of Circumcision

This is the longest and most complicated speech so far in the book of Genesis. Before diving into its details, it's helpful to get an overview of its main content and literary organization.

Macro Design of Genesis 17

At its most basic, the chapter is designed in a simple three-step progression.

Genesis 17:1-16

A - God's Speech to Avraham: Covenant, **Promise of Seed**, Summons to **Circumcise Every Male**

Genesis 17:17-22

B - God and Avraham Dialogue about the **Promise of Seed**

Genesis 17:23-27

A' - Avraham **Circumcises Every Male** in His House

Genesis 17:1-27 (3-Step). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Genesis 17:1-3

Speech 1, Initial Statement: Yahweh Will Make a Covenant With Avram

- a - When Avram was a son of ninety-nine years,
- b - and Yahweh became visible to Avram, and said to him
- c - "I will give **my covenant** between me and between you
- d - **I will multiply you very very much** "
- e - **And Avram fell upon his face**

Genesis 17:4-16

17:4-8

A - Speech 2, The Covenant: New Name Blessing, Royal Seed, Land

- "And Elohim spoke to him saying ..."

As for me [Yahweh] ...

My covenant is with you

No longer will your name be called Avram, but "Avraham" will be your name

I will make you a multitude of nations
I will make you fruitful, very very much
and kings will come from you

17:9-14

B - Speech 3, Sign of the Covenant: Circumcision, Cut Off Foreskin

- "And Elohim said to Avraham ..."

As for you [Avraham] ...

This is **my covenant** that you will keep: **Circumcise** every male ...

Any son of eight days will be **circumcised**, every male of your generations ...

The foreskin of a male that is not **circumcised** ... he will cut off from his people ...

17:15-16

A' - Speech 4, The Promise: New Name Blessing, Son, Royal Seed

- "And Elohim said to Avraham ..."

As for Sarai ...

Her name will not be called Sarai, but "Sarah" is her name

And I will bless her

and she will become nations

kings of peoples will be from her

Genesis 17:17-22

Yahweh's Appeal to Israel: Turn to Me and Live!

e - And Avram fell upon his face

d - "Will there be a birth for a son of one-hundred years?!"

c - "I will establish **my covenant** with Yitskhaq ..."

b - **"I will multiply [Yishmael] very very much"**

a - And he finished speaking to him, and Elohim went up from Avraham

Genesis 17:23-27

Narrative: Fulfillment of the Circumcision Command

- And Avraham took Yishmael ... everyone born of his house, every male ...
and he **circumcised** the flesh of their foreskin just as God said.

Genesis 17:1-27 (Detailed). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This literary organization highlights a number of key themes in the chapter.

The narrative of a divine command (Gen. 17:1-22) followed by a narrative of Abraham fulfilling the divine command exactly (Gen. 17:23-27) highlights Abraham's obedience and trust in Yahweh. Even though it must have been a painful experience, Abraham circumcised himself and every male in his household out of obedient trust in God's word.

The five speeches are designed in a symmetrical order, and each one has a distinct main point and rhetorical thrust.

Genesis 17:1-3

Speech 1

- Avram is summoned to be faithful to Yahweh
- Initial statement: I will set up a covenant between you and me and bless you

A- Genesis 17:4-8

Speech 2

- Avram re-created into Abraham: father of many nations, including kings
- Yahweh will be the *Elohim* of Abraham and his **seed** and they will inherit **land**

B- Genesis 17:9-14

Speech 3

- Abraham's covenant obligation: circumcision as covenant sign

A'- Genesis 17:15-16

Speech 4

- Sarai is re-created into Sarah: blessing, son, kings will come from her

Genesis 17:17-22

Dialogue + Speech 5

- Abraham proposes Yishmael
- God chooses Yitskhaq through Sarah as the chosen son

Genesis 17:1-22. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 17:1-27

Genesis 17:1-3

¹ And Avram was ninety nine years old,
and Yahweh became seen to Avram,
and he said to him,
 "I am El-Shaddai.
 Walk before my face,
 and be blameless;
² then I will give a **covenant** **between me and between you**,
 and **I will multiply you very, very much**."
³ And Avram fell down upon his face.

Genesis 17:4-16

And Elohim spoke to him, saying:
⁴ " **As for me**, look, **my covenant** **is with you**,
and you will become a father of a multitude of nations,
⁵ **and no longer will your name be called, 'Avram,'**
but your name will be 'Avraham,'
because I will give you to be a multitude of nations,
⁶ and **I will make you fruitful, very very much**,
and I will give you to become nations,
and **kings will come from you**,
⁷ and I will **establish my covenant**
between me and between you,
and between your seed after you for their generations,
as **an eternal covenant**,
to be Elohim for you,
and for your seed after you
⁸ and I will give to you and to **your seed after you**,
the land of your sojourning,
all **the land** of Canaan,
for **an eternal possession**,
and I will be Elohim for them."

⁹ And Elohim said to Avraham,
 "**And as for you**, **you will keep** **my covenant**,
 you and **your seed after you** for their generations.
¹⁰ This is **my covenant** that **y'all will keep**,
 between me and between y'all,
 and between your seed after you:
 circumcise for yourselves **every male**.
¹¹ And y'all will **circumcise** **the flesh of your foreskin**,
 and that will be as a symbol of **the covenant**,

B

between me and between y'all.

- 12 When there's a son of eight days,
he will be **circumcised** for you, **every male** for your generations;
one born of the house or purchased with silver,
from any son of a foreigner who is not from your **seed**;
- 13 he will certainly be **circumcised**,
that one born of the house or purchased with silver;
and **my covenant** will be **in your flesh**,
for **an eternal covenant**.
- 14 And a foreskinned male that is not **circumcised** in **the flesh of his foreskin**,
that person will be cut off from his people,
he has violated **my covenant**.

A'

- 15 And Elohim said to Avraham,
" **As for Sarai** your wife,
you will not call her name 'Sarai';
because her name is 'Sarah.' [= "Queen"]
- 16 And I will **bless** her,
and also, I will give to you from her a son,
and I will **bless** her,
and she will become nations,
kings of people groups will be from her."

Genesis 17:17-22

- 17 And Avraham fell on his face,
and **he laughed (= yitskhaq)** and said in his heart,
"Will there **be a birth** for a son of a hundred years?!"
Or Sarah, a daughter of ninety years, she will **give birth?!"**
- 18 And Avraham said to Elohim,
"If only **Yishmael** could live before your face!"

A

- 19 And Elohim said,
"Nonetheless, Sarah your wife will **birth** for you a son,
and you will call his name, '**Yitskhaq**' [= "Laughter"],
and **I will establish my covenant** with him,
for **an eternal covenant** for his **seed** after him.

- 20 And as for **Yishmael**, I have **heard** you.
look, I have **blessed** him,
and I will make him **fruitful**,

R

and I will make him **multiply**, very very much.
Twelve princes he will **cause to be born**,
and I will give him to be a **great nation**.

A' 21 But **I will establish my covenant** with **Yitskhaq**,
whom Sarah will **birth** for you at this appointed time in the year after."

22 And he finished speaking to him,
and Elohim went up from Avraham.

Genesis 17:23-27

23 And Avraham took **Yishmael** his son,
and all those born of his house,
and all those purchased with silver,
every male among the men of Avraham's house,
and he **circumcised** the flesh of their foreskin,
on that very day,
just as Elohim had spoken to him.

a 24 And Avraham was **a son of ninety nine years,**
b when he was **circumcised** in **the flesh of his foreskin,**
a' 25 and Yishmael his son was **a son of thirteen years,**
b' when he was **circumcised** in **the flesh of his foreskin.**

26 **On that very day,**
Avraham was **circumcised**, and **Yishmael** his son,
27 **and all the men of his house,**
those born of the house
and those purchased with silver from a foreigner,
they were **circumcised** with him.

Genesis 17:1-27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The De-creation and Re-creation of Avram and Sarai

This complex narrative is designed to culminate the themes at work so far in all of Genesis 1-17, and especially the earlier patterns of creation and Eden and of flood and covenant.

Numerous details in this chapter only make sense based on our ability to track the hyperlinks and analogies with these earlier narratives.

Avraham and Noah, Circumcision and Flood

Avraham	Noah
Gen. 17:1 “ Walk (התהלך) before me and be blameless (תמים)”	Gen. 6:9b “Noah was a righteous man, blameless (תמים) in his generations, he walked (התהלך) with God.”
Gen. 17:4-5 “You will become the father of a multitude of nations (אב ... גוים)”	Gen. 6:10 “Noah had three sons, Shem, Ham, and Japheth” who become the patriarchs of the 70 nations in Genesis 10.
Gen. 17:7 “And I will establish my covenant (והקמתי את בריתי between you and between you and between your seed after you (זרעך אחריך) for generations, as an eternal covenant.”	Gen. 6:18 “And I will establish my covenant (והקמתי את בריתי with you” Gen. 9:9 “And I will establish my covenant (מקים את בריתי with you and with your seed after you (את זרעכם אחריכם)”
Gen. 17:11 “And you will circumcise the flesh of your foreskin, and it will be for a sign of the covenant between me and between you.” Gen. 17:13 “And my covenant will be in your flesh (בבשרכם) for an eternal covenant ” (ברית עולם)	Gen. 9:12 “This will be a sign of the covenant between me and between you” Gen. 9:17 “This is the sign of the covenant which I am establishing between me and between all flesh (בשר)”
Gen. 17:26 “on that very day (בעצם היום הזה), just as God spoke to him”	Gen. 7:13 “On that very day (בעצם היום הזה) Noah went ... into the ark.” + Gen. 7:16 “just as God commanded him”
Avraham and Noah, Circumcision and Flood. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

This linking of Noah and Avraham creates a clear set of similarities and contrasts between the two characters and God’s covenant with them.

While Noah simply was “blameless” when God initiated the conversation, Avram, on the other hand, has just participated in a great sin against Hagar (on analogy with Gen. 3 and 6), resulting in the oppression of the immigrant, so he now has to be commanded: “be blameless.”

The “sign” of the covenant for Noah and Avraham is crucial for understanding the nature and purpose of circumcision. In Genesis 9:12-17, the “sign” of the covenant is the rainbow which shines when the rain clouds come. Rain was the instrument of divine judgment, and so the rainbow is a reminder of humanity’s evil that brought the flood. But rain was also the divine response of judgment combined with covenant love that

spared a remnant. In a similar way, in [Genesis 17:11, 13](#), the “sign” of the covenant marks the instrument of human failure, that is, Avraham’s genitals (this seems hinted at in the design pattern of [Gen. 9:17](#) “covenant with flesh”). But the judgment is on the part of Avraham’s body that will become fruitful for the nation.

Rainbow	Circumcision
A symbol of God's judgment and mercy that brought a remnant safely through death to new life before God.	A symbol of God’s judgment on Avraham’s penis, which he used to abuse Hagar. But also a symbol of mercy, for his future seed will come from his “cut off” genitals that belong to God alone.
Gen. 9:9 God is going to “establish my covenant with you and your seed after you” (הקים + ברית + זרע)	Gen. 17:7 God is going to “establish my covenant with you and your seed after you” (הקים + ברית + זרע)
Gen. 9:12 The bow in the skies is the “sign of the covenant” (אות הברית)	Gen. 17:11 Circumcision is the “sign of the covenant” (אות ברית)
Gen. 9:10-12 The flood (המבול) “cut off all flesh” (בשר + כרת), and so God’s covenant is with Noah and “all living beings” (כל נפש), that they will not be “cut off by the flood” (המבול + כרת).	Gen. 17:10-14 Circumcision (המול) involves cutting off “flesh” (בשר) from “every male” (כל זכר), and every “living-person” (נפש) who is not circumcised will be “cut off from” (מן ... כרת) his people.
<i>Rainbow and Circumcision. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

Just as the flood ([המבול](#)) was a judgment of cutting off ([יכרת](#)) all flesh ([בשר](#)) in [Genesis 9:11](#), so now circumcision ([המול](#)) is a "local flood" of judgment that cuts off ([נכרתה](#)) the flesh ([בשר](#)) of the foreskin of Avraham’s family in [Gen. 17:10-14](#). It is as if Avraham’s sin “cuts off” all hope except for an Yitskhaq-remnant (Isaac-remnant) that God will miraculously bring into the world through Sarah’s womb // the Noah-remnant that God miraculously saves through the ark. Both events happen “on the very day” ([בעצם היום הזה](#)) in [Gen. 7:13](#) and [Gen. 17:24, 26](#)) of the command.

⁸ **And Elohim said to Noah** and to his sons **with him** , saying,

⁹ “And I myself, behold, **I set up my covenant with y’all,**
and with your seed after you;

¹⁰ and **with every living creature** that is **with you** ,
the birds, the beasts, and every **living creature** of the land **with you** ;
from everything that comes out of the ark,
even every **living creature** of the land.

¹¹ And **I set up my covenant with y’all;**
and never again will **all flesh** **be cut off by the waters of the flood** ,

and never again will there be a flood to ruin the land.”

12 And Elohim said,

“This is **the sign of the covenant** which I am giving
between me and between you
and between every living creature that is **with you**, for everlasting generations;

¹³ I give **my bow in the cloud**,
and it will be for **a sign of a covenant**
between me and between the land;

¹⁴ and it will come about when **I cloud a cloud** over the land,
that **it will be seen**, **the bow in the cloud**,

¹⁵ and **I will remember my covenant**,
which is **between me and between you**
and between every living creature of all flesh;
and never again will the waters become a flood to ruin all flesh.

¹⁶ And **the bow is in the cloud**,
then **I will see it**,
to remember **the everlasting covenant**
between Elohim and between every living creature,
with all flesh that is on the land.”

17 And Elohim said to Noah,

“This is **the sign of the covenant which I have set up**
between me and all flesh that is on the land.”

Genesis 9:8-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Both covenants with Avraham and Noah have a universal scope. Noah’s sons produce all the nations of Genesis 10, and Avraham will become the father of many nations. This aligns well with the fact that Yishmael is the first to be circumcised in Genesis 17, and that circumcision is associated with the inclusion of the nations into God’s covenant with Avraham.

The blessed sons: Just as two of Noah’s three sons found blessing and fruitfulness after the flood (Japheth and Shem), so also Avraham’s two sons Yishmael and Yitskhaq (Isaac) will be blessed and become great nations. In both cases, only the younger of the two will become the line of the covenant (Shem and Yitskhaq), while the older (Japheth and Yishmael) will be blessed, but not as the carrier of covenant blessing.

The role of Sarah in this story is like the ark (תבה). She is the vehicle of the future seed, but her distorted efforts to build her own Eden-blessing (remember “build” בנה in [Gen. 16:2](#)) have also replayed the fall and introduced division into Avraham’s family. Her role in this way also recalls the ark’s role as an analogy to the woman in Genesis 2 ([Gen. 2:22](#) בנה). Note how Sarah here ([Gen. 17:17](#)) is also called “a daughter of 90 years” which is an anagram of the word “ark” ([Gen 6:14](#) תבה // הבת [Gen. 17:17](#))

Avraham and Sarah, Adam and Eve

The analogies to the Eden story are also important. God’s covenant with Noah was a kind of re-creation of his identity, and God also remakes Avraham and Sarah’s identity in a way similar to Adam and Eve.

God's blessing on Avraham and Sarah Gen. 17:2 “I will multiply (רבה) you very very much” Gen. 17:6 “I will make you fruitful (פרה) very very much” Gen. 17:16 “I will bless [Sarah]”	God's blessing on humanity, male and female Gen. 1:28 And Elohim blessed them, saying, “Be fruitful (פרה) and multiply (רבה), fill the land and subdue it ...”
God re-names Avram and Sarai Gen. 17:5 “No longer will your name be called, ‘Avram,’ but your name will be ‘Avraham,’ because I will make you a father of a multitude of nations.” Gen. 17:15 “Sarai your wife, you will not call her name ‘Sarai,’ because her name is ‘Sarah.’”	Humanity is named, then renamed Gen. 1:26 “Let us make ‘human’ (אדם) in our image ... let them rule ...” Gen. 2:23 “She shall be called Woman (אשה), because she was taken out of man (איש).” Gen. 3:20 Now the man called his wife’s name “Khavvah” (חווה) because she was the mother of all living (חי).
<i>Avraham and Sarah, Adam and Eve. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

In Adam and Eve’s story, she is named before their folly, and her name symbolizes the “two-in-one” union of man/woman. After the folly, she is named based on her reproductive function in their relationship, “Mother of All Living.”

In Avraham and Sarah’s story, both are renamed after their shared folly with Hagar. God will maintain his promise to them, but only after “cutting of flesh” from Avraham’s genitals and marking them as belonging to God. The new names signify the new, God-given identity that Avraham and Sarah now have. Their lives and reproductive abilities belong wholly to God, and from them God will create a nation of seed and kings. Their new names reflect this: Avraham means Father of a Multitude; Sarah means Queen (i.e., mother of kings).

Father and Mother of Many Nations: Yishmael and Yitskhaq

This chapter carries forward the pattern of Yahweh selecting one chosen lineage from among a larger set of siblings. Now that Avraham and Sarah have abused Hagar and produced Yishmael, they will become the parents of a family made up of many nations, starting first with Yishmael.

This is one step in a larger design pattern that starts back with Cain and Abel.

Chosen for Covenant	Not Chosen	Resulting People Group
Abel + Seth	Cain	Kenites
Shem	Japheth, Ham	The island nations, Canaanites
Avraham	Nakhor, Lot	Moabites, Ammonites
Yitskhaq	Yishmael, sons of Qeturah	Ishmaelites, Midianites, eastern tribes
Yaaqov	Esau	Edomites
Judah	11 brothers	Northern tribes
David	Saul	Benjaminite
Family of Judah	Northern tribes	Samaritans
<i>Father and Mother of Many Nations. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>		

Notice, however, that even though Yishmael is not chosen as the lineage of the covenant and royal seed, God affirms that he will bless him and his family in precisely the language of the Eden blessing, but also in anticipation of the later 12 sons of Yaakov (Jacob).

Genesis 17:20 Instructor’s Translation

Look, I am going to bless [Yishmael], and I will make him fruitful, very very much. He will become the father of twelve princes, and I will make him a great nation.

Reflection Question

How is circumcision both an act of God’s judgment and and act of grace?